

# Problem & Domain Brief

## 1 Problem

Small businesses receive enquiries through a variety of channels, including website contact forms, WhatsApp, Instagram direct messages, referrals, and other direct enquiries. These interactions are often managed through separate inboxes or informal notes.

The problem is not necessarily a lack of effort. The problem is that there is no consistent mechanism for tracking which leads have been contacted, which are still active, what was discussed previously, and which leads require follow-up.

As a result, follow-ups are easily delayed or forgotten. Potential customers may move on to a competitor before the business owner realises that an opportunity has been lost.

The core problem can therefore be stated as:

Small businesses lack a simple, reliable way to keep track of inbound enquiries and know which leads require their attention.

## 2 Domain

The system operates within the domain of **small-business inbound lead management**.

A lead represents a prospective customer who has made an enquiry about a product or service. The lead may originate from a website form, WhatsApp, Instagram, a referral, or another direct channel.

The typical lead lifecycle is intentionally simple:

**Enquiry Received → Contacted → Follow-up Required → Converted / Lost**

The system therefore needs to preserve a small amount of information about each lead, including who the person is, how they made contact, what was discussed, the current status of the enquiry, and when further action is required.

## 3 Target Users

The primary user is a **one- or two-person business** that receives a steady but relatively small volume of inbound enquiries, approximately 5–50 per month.

Examples include:

- contractors and tradespeople;
- private practices;
- tutoring services;

- small agencies;
- independent professional service providers.

These users typically do not have a dedicated sales team or sales operations function. They are responsible for receiving enquiries, responding to customers, and deciding when follow-up is required.

They are not primarily looking for a sophisticated customer relationship management platform. Their immediate need is simpler: to avoid forgetting potential customers.

## 4 Current Behaviour and Existing Solutions

Businesses currently manage inbound leads through a mixture of informal and general-purpose tools. Common approaches include email and messaging inboxes, spreadsheets, note-taking applications, memory, and full CRM platforms.

| Approach                               | Problem for the Target User                                                                                                                                            |
|----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Enterprise CRM                         | Designed for sales teams and complex organisations. Typically introduces unnecessary configuration, cost, and operational complexity.                                  |
| Mid-market CRM                         | Provides useful functionality, but often includes pipelines, forecasting, automation, and other capabilities that are unnecessary for a small owner-operated business. |
| Spreadsheets and general-purpose tools | Inexpensive and flexible, but largely passive. They store information without actively helping the user identify overdue or upcoming follow-ups.                       |
| Doing nothing                          | Requires no setup, but relies entirely on memory and existing inboxes. Missed follow-ups remain largely invisible to the business owner.                               |

Table 1: Common approaches to managing inbound leads

The most significant practical alternative is therefore not another CRM platform. It is the combination of **existing inboxes, spreadsheets, notes, and good intentions**.

## 5 The Gap

Existing solutions tend to fall into two broad categories.

**Too much:** full CRM platforms designed around sales teams, pipelines, automation, forecasting, and organisational processes.

**Too little:** spreadsheets, notes, and inboxes that can store information but do not provide a clear view of lead status or follow-up responsibilities.

The opportunity lies in the narrow middle: a lightweight system that provides the essential visibility and follow-up capabilities of a CRM without the complexity associated with a full sales platform.

The central question the system should help the user answer is:

*Which leads need my attention today, and what did I last say to them?*

## 6 Contextual Constraints

Several characteristics of the target environment influence the domain.

- **Small-scale usage:** The system is intended for a single business owner or a very small team, rather than a large sales organisation.
- **Mobile access:** Users may need to check or update leads while working away from a desk, making mobile usability an important consideration.
- **Variable connectivity:** Users may encounter slow or unreliable network connections, so the system should remain usable without assuming consistently fast connectivity.
- **Low tolerance for complexity:** The value of the system depends on being easier to adopt and maintain than a conventional CRM.

## 7 Domain Boundary

The problem domain is deliberately limited to the management of inbound leads after an initial enquiry has been received.

The domain includes:

- capturing lead information;
- recording the source of an enquiry;
- tracking lead status;
- recording notes and interaction history;
- identifying leads that require follow-up;
- recording whether a lead was converted or lost.

The domain does not require the system to become a complete sales or marketing platform. Activities such as campaign management, advanced forecasting, organisational permissions, and complex sales pipelines fall outside the problem being addressed.

## 8 Problem Statement

Small businesses lose potential customers because inbound enquiries are distributed across multiple channels and are difficult to track consistently. Existing CRM systems are often unnecessarily complex for these businesses, while spreadsheets and informal tools are too passive to reliably manage follow-up.

The problem is therefore to provide a simple mechanism for maintaining a clear view of inbound leads, their current status, their interaction history, and the actions that require attention.